14

Contemporary Myanmar: Optimism and Caution

The constitutional referendum went forward although it was delayed in 47 of the most significantly affected areas. Media coverage of the referendum was overwhelming, and the plight of the suffering peasants impacted by Nargis was overlooked. The results announced by the State Peace and Development Council (SPDC) were an overwhelming 92 percent voting in favor of the constitution. The government claimed a clear mandate to move forward toward democratic elections scheduled for 2010.

A VISITOR COMPLICATES MATTERS

A bizarre turn of events dominated Myanmar during the summer of 2009. On May 3, American John Yettaw, a devout Mormon from Missouri swam across Lake Inlay and arrived at the residence of Aung San Suu Kyi. After warning her of a possible assassination attempt, the obviously deranged Yettaw was reluctantly permitted to stay at the house for two evenings. This was an act of compassion on behalf of Aung San Suu Kyi as Yettaw was both physically and mentally not well. This was actually the second time Yettaw had attempted to see Suu Kyi. An earlier attempt had failed and Myanmar security personnel had turned him back. At the time of his successful arrival, the 53-year-old American was in fragile health as he suffered from diabetes and epileptic seizures. After departing from the house, Yettaw was detained and later charged by the authorities. On May 7, authorities searched Suu Kyi's residence and later arrested her along with the two long-term houseguests. Suu Kyi was charged with breaking the terms of her house arrest. Suu Kyi was held at the infamous Insein prison for the duration of the trial, which lasted from mid May until August 11. The trial was marred with delays as the regime turned the event into a farcical affair. The defense would only be allotted one witness to testify.